▶ ODISHA

# NAVEEN'S ARK IN CHOPPY SEA

**'Non-alignment' in Delhi is proving costly back home as BJD is rocked by a wave of resignations**

ANI



**ALL ABOARD?** Former CM Naveen Patnaik visits a church in Bhubaneswar on Christmas last year

In fact, these exits are part of a larger wave of disenchantment among senior leaders who have grown increasingly vocal about the direction of the party since its shock defeat in the 2024 general election. Other high-profile resignations, including those of Rajya Sabha MPs Mamata Mohanta and Sujeet Kumar in 2024, had not created similar ripples largely because they lacked Rao's grassroots stature. This time, however, the tremors are unmistakable.

Former BJD MP and journalist Tathagat Satpathy, who has retired from politics, argues the party had "passed its best" and might eventually have to re-emerge under a new name, given the Congress's long eclipse in Odisha. Echoing him, ex-MLA Amar Satpathy, too, warns that the party's acceptance among the people is declining steadily. Abstaining from the V-P's election is seen to have dented the BJD's image as a strong, independent regional force.

**Takeaways**

- **South Odisha veteran Bhaskar Rao, a loyalist since Biju days, quits; ex-minister, cadre follow**
- **Factionalism, wave of dissent since 2024 loss prompt critics to say BJD has "passed its best"**

That enfeeblement is breeding factionalism. Kendrapara satrap and ex-minister Prafulla Mallik threatened to resign in the wake of Rao-Himirika and was suspended. "Commitment is proved in difficult times," said BJD spokesperson Pratap Jena, scoffing at those who "fail the test of loyalty". No dearth of them these days, though. In Jajpur's Dharmasala, nearly 70 local BJD leaders jumped ship to the BJP.

The next test for the BJD comes only in 2027, with panchayat polls. But it seems to have entered a phase of precarity and self-doubt—portending what may be big changes to Odisha's political map. ■